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Transportation Lobbyists Have Donated Thousands to Sean Duffy’s Son-in-Law as He Runs for Congress



Secretary of Transportation Sean Duffy's son-in-law is running a congressional campaign in Wisconsin while benefitting from donations from the transportation lobby. DANIEL HEUER/BLOOMBERG/GETTY IMAGES

Industry money has been pouring into the congressional campaign of Michael Alfonso, a 26-year-old political unknown from Wisconsin. The candidate’s father-in-law happens to be the U.S. secretary of transportation.



by **Megan O’Matz**

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The \$16 billion Hudson Tunnel Project, under construction between Manhattan and New Jersey, will improve passenger rail service, an important issue for New York City commuters. It would seem to have nothing to do with what’s happening in northern Wisconsin.

But after the White House froze federal grant funding for the project in the fall, citing concerns about diversity and equity measures, lobbyists with an interest in the tunnel donated \$2,500 to a political novice running in the Republican primary in Wisconsin’s 7th Congressional District.

The young candidate, Michael Alfonso, has no sway over the matter. However, his father-in-law does: Sean Duffy is secretary of the U.S. Department of Transportation.

The contributions are among dozens to Alfonso’s campaign from lobbyists, business executives and political action committees tied to industries — from rails and highways to shipping and air travel — that Duffy’s department funds and regulates. His department also oversees the Federal Aviation Administration.

Duffy held the 7th Congressional District seat for nearly a decade before resigning in 2019. He was succeeded by Tom Tiffany, who is now running for Wisconsin governor, leaving the seat open again. Alfonso, 26, who has worked in construction and podcasting, has been endorsed by President Donald Trump.

A ProPublica analysis found that many of the Alfonso donors with transportation interests had never given to Duffy or Tiffany. While legal, such donations set up the appearance that helping Alfonso might assist the donors with issues influenced by Duffy. (Politico has reported on some of these contributions.)

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questions.”

This is not the first time a Cabinet secretary’s relative has created thorny ethical issues. During the first Trump administration, Transportation Secretary Elaine Chao [made headlines](#) for appearing to give preferential treatment to Kentucky officials for millions of dollars in infrastructure grants. Kentucky is the home state of her husband, Mitch McConnell, then Senate majority leader. At the time, Chao’s office denied showing any favoritism, saying that Kentucky’s share was not out of the ordinary.

And in 2012, under President Barack Obama, Agriculture Secretary Tom Vilsack, an Iowa Democrat, [fielded questions](#) about the separation between U.S. Department of Agriculture business and the campaign of his wife, Christie, who was running for Congress. Christie Vilsack told ProPublica in an interview that the couple was careful about making sure her husband was not involved in the campaign, other than to support her at some debates and on election night. He “never did any fundraising at all,” she said.

An influential member of Trump’s Cabinet, Duffy has been openly assisting his son-in-law’s campaign. The notice for a November “meet and greet” with Alfonso in Wausau, Wisconsin, mentioned that Duffy would be a special guest, as did an invitation for another December fundraiser.

Among the sponsors for the December event was the political action committee for Delta Air Lines. The invitation included a caveat: “Sean Duffy is not soliciting funds in connection with this event.”

Alfonso’s campaign did not respond to requests from ProPublica for an interview or for comment. A spokesperson for Duffy, Nathaniel Sizemore, provided a written statement saying: “The Secretary attends fundraising events in his personal capacity. Regulatory decisions are guided by career safety professionals, the law, and the facts.”

Nothing in law bars Duffy from campaigning for his son-in-law, so long as he goes about it on his personal time, does not use government resources and does not promise to take some official action in exchange for a contribution.

Alfonso is using the same fundraising consultant, Kirstin Hopkins, that Duffy employed, Federal Election Commission records show. In addition, Alfonso has received help with ads and mailers from a super PAC, the Northwoods Future PAC, that is funded with \$1 million from Duffy’s former campaign committee. Alfonso’s familial advantage [has irked some Wisconsin Republicans](#) who don’t want the newcomer to glide into such an important position.

Through his own campaign committee, Alfonso had raised a little over \$305,000 as of the end of 2025, the latest filing available. By law, contributions for each election are limited to \$3,500 from individuals and \$5,000 from political action committees. Donors can contribute to more than one election at the same time, such as a primary race and a general.

Alfonso’s donors include lobbyist Jeffrey Miller, a finance chair of Trump’s most recent inaugural committee. In December, Miller and his company’s chief operating officer donated separately to Alfonso, for a combined \$8,500. No one listing their firm, Miller Strategies, as an employer had donated to either Duffy or Tiffany in the past, according to FEC records.

Lobbyist disclosure reports show that Miller lobbied the Transportation Department in 2025 on behalf of at least nine companies, one New York county and one Native American tribe. The issues included airport signage regulation, aviation permitting for the developer of a supersonic airliner and advancements in GPS technology. Miller reported advocating for Archer Aviation regarding electric vertical takeoff and landing aircraft technology, known as eVTOL — the basis for future flying cars.

Earlier this month, Duffy announced [a first-of-its-kind FAA pilot program](#) to test eVTOL technology in eight demonstration projects across 26 states. [Archer was among the companies](#) selected to participate, according to the Transportation Department. In a video accompanying the announcement, Duffy spoke enthusiastically about the technology, envisioning “Ubers in the air” taking people from one airport to the next and beyond. He said, “eVTOLs are going to make the airspace far more interesting and far more fun, and we have to be prepared for that.”

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Miller did not return calls or emails seeking comment.

Alfonso graduated in 2022 from the University of Wisconsin with a math degree. He moved to Florida for a time to help produce a popular podcast hosted by Dan Bongino, a Trump supporter who later served a brief stint as deputy director of the FBI. (Bongino is back podcasting again.)

By Alfonso’s account, he and Trump first met in 2022 at Alfonso’s wedding to Duffy’s daughter, Evita. The reception took place at one of Trump’s New Jersey golf courses.

Alfonso has said that in an Oval Office meeting after he decided to run for Congress, he pledged loyalty to the president. “I promised him that I would always be America first, I would always fight for his agenda and that nobody would ever outwork me,” Alfonso told Mark Halperin, another podcaster.

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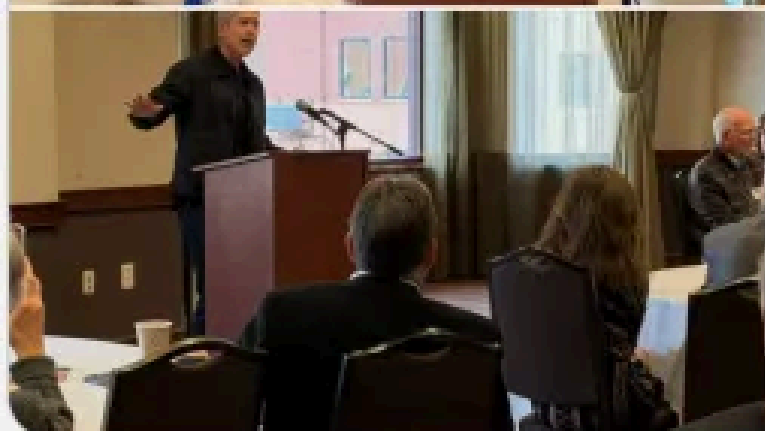


Michael Alfonso ✓

@MikeAlfonsoWI



Huge thank you to Sean Duffy and everyone who came out to our first official campaign event in my hometown of Wausau! Grateful for the support — and fired up for what's ahead! 🇺🇸



4:11 PM · Nov 11, 2025 · 9,173 Views

In a post on X, Alfonso thanked his father-in-law for joining him on the campaign trail in Wisconsin last November. x

The following month, the transportation secretary appeared at a campaign fundraiser for Alfonso at a hotel in Green Bay, near the storied Lambeau Field. The donors in attendance included Sharad Tak of Bethesda, Maryland, the CEO of ST LNG, a company seeking a DOT-issued license to construct and operate a deep-water port offshore of Matagorda, Texas, to load liquefied natural gas onto carriers.

Tak gave \$500 to the campaign, and his wife, Mahinder, who did not attend the function, gave \$7,000. Neither had donated to Duffy or Tiffany.

Tak did not reply to ProPublica's request for an interview but asked a longtime friend of his, Ann Murphy of Green Bay, who works as a consultant for him, to respond. Tak owns a paper mill in Oconto Falls, north of Green Bay. It is not in the 7th Congressional District. But Murphy said Tak was visiting the state and agreed, at her request, to attend the fundraiser for Alfonso.

She said in an interview that the Texas liquefied natural gas project had no bearing on Tak's campaign contribution. "Absolutely not."

It's typical, she said, for Tak and his wife to support causes, both political and philanthropic, that Murphy and her husband find worthwhile — and vice versa.

"We were very excited about Michael," Murphy said of Alfonso, likening him to Charlie Kirk, the founder of Turning Point USA who inspired many young people before being killed last year. "And he does have the endorsement of President Trump."

Others donating to Alfonso's candidacy include political action committees for employees of the military jetmaker Lockheed Martin, which is subject to FAA

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The PAC for Brightline, a high-speed train service in Florida, also donated, giving \$2,500 in December. Brightline trains have struck and killed more than 180 pedestrians or drivers at crossings since 2017, according to an investigation by the [Miami Herald and WLRN](#). Duffy promised at a [congressional committee](#) hearing in July to work to “drive down the number of deaths.” In September, [he announced](#) that his department would distribute [\\$42 million](#) to improve safety along the line. In a statement to the Florida news organizations, [Brightline officials blamed the deaths](#) on suicides and the “reckless” behavior of people who put themselves in harm’s way.

Brightline, T-Mobile and Lockheed Martin did not respond to ProPublica’s requests for comment. On its website, [Lockheed notes](#) that it complies with all applicable laws and regulations with regard to its political and public policy activities.

Alfonso’s campaign has drawn donations from others in the heavily regulated railroad sector. They include Peter Bartek, founder of FTS Rail, which manufactures battery-powered railroad repair tools and sensors that detect rail breaks caused by extreme heat or cold. He gave \$3,644 in November. Duffy appointed [Bartek last July to serve](#) on a DOT advisory committee.

Bartek had never given to a candidate in the district before. In an interview, he said he read a news article about Alfonso’s campaign and decided to donate. “I like Secretary Duffy very much,” he said, “and I thought very simply, boy, if he’s anything like his father-in-law, it would be nice to support him as well.”

He said in a text that he didn’t know Duffy personally and was not involved in Alfonso’s campaign or fundraising.

In New York, construction on the Hudson Tunnel Project to improve commuter rail service came to a screeching halt in early February after the federal government [cut off funds](#). A court intervened, ordering the money released, and work resumed. A bistate commission overseeing the project [warned this month](#) that it could face disruptions again in upcoming months if federal disbursements do not continue.

In response to outreach from ProPublica, an executive at Venture Government Strategies, whose lobbyists for the tunnel project gave a combined \$2,500 to Alfonso, said in an email the company had no comment.

On his campaign website, Alfonso lists a dozen issues “that matter to us” — ranging from education and health care to immigration. He wants to “make farms and families strong,” “give Gen Z a voice” and work against access to abortion.

Transportation issues are not among those priorities, but he still is getting support from General Motors, which regularly lobbies DOT on various issues, including fuel economy, vehicle safety and emissions standards, and other mandates. The giant car manufacturer also gave to Duffy when he was running for the congressional seat, and the transportation secretary has become a booster. (GM did not respond to ProPublica’s request for comment.)

In mid-December, viewers of social media saw Duffy slide behind the wheel of a sleek, black, limited-edition Corvette, imbued with patriotic insignia to celebrate the nation’s upcoming 250th birthday.

“Over 1,000 horsepower,” Duffy said [in a promotional video](#), emphasizing the dynamic features of the \$200,000 supercar. “We’re going to take this bad boy on a little test drive to the Army-Navy game.” Off he went.

The video, uploaded to the social media platform X, highlighted a travel app the carmaker made in partnership with the Department of Transportation, while also showcasing Chevrolet’s automotive series dubbed Stars and Steel.

The post received over 130,000 views: valuable advertisement for the storied carmaker, General Motors. A couple of weeks later, GM’s political action committee donated \$1,000 to Alfonso.



Megan O’Matz



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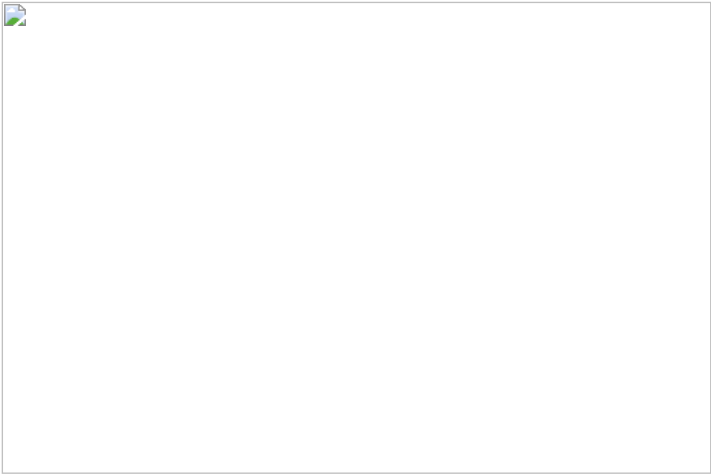
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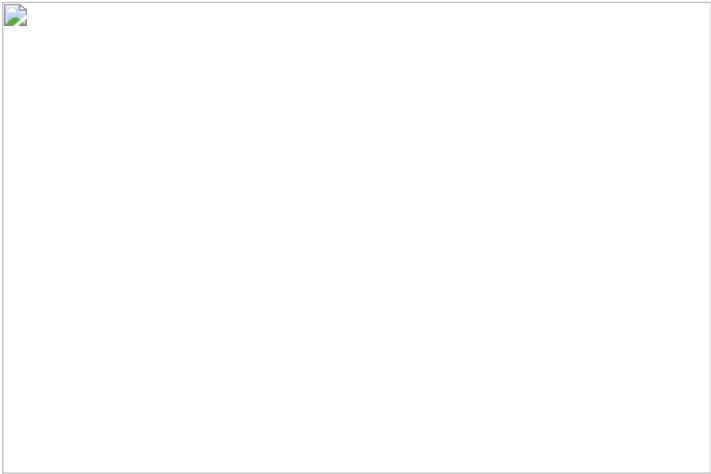
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